

The Origins of Fact-Checking Authority for Election Fraud Claims

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We propose a novel survey experiment extending Berlinski et al. (2023) by including new treatment conditions relating to the source of the fact-checking messages; this novel survey experiment would be conducted simultaneously with our replication. One of the main findings of Berlinski et al. (2023) is that even when tweets with unverified claims of election fraud were supplemented by fact-checking tweets, voters were still likely to have decreased confidence in election integrity. However, the original study looked only at social media posts from media organizations for fact-checking; our novel experiment adds two new treatment conditions - one where posts claiming election fraud were supplemented by posts from elections officials fact-checking misinformation about elections, and one where posts claiming election fraud were supplemented by fact-checking posts from think tanks - to the four existing treatment arms in the original study. By varying the source of the fact-checking, our novel study answers the following question: to what extent does the source influence the effect of fact-checking misinformation on trust in elections? We therefore touch upon how source credibility may influence voters' decisions to believe (or disbelieve) election-related misinformation (Clemm von Hohenberg and Guess 2023). **This proposal includes modifications from the original submission; the major changes are that we are requesting a 9,000-individual sample for the novel-replication combined study, and proposing a new treatment assignment strategy based on newly run simulations.**

Background

In the last decade, misinformation about elections has proliferated, particularly in an increasingly technological-reliant age (Allcott and Gentzkow 2017). This has led to consequences for both voters' beliefs in election integrity, as well as how elections officials must respond to claims against voter fraud (Fahey 2023; Barrett et al. 2026). To combat this rise in misinformation, fact-checking has become a potential strategy for reducing the impacts that misinformation has on voters. There is substantial debate as to whether providing accurate information about elections to correct misinformation may be effective at combating the impact of elections-related misinformation on voter confidence (Berlinski et al. 2023; Fahey 2023; Suttman-Lea and Merivaki 2023). In these studies, fact-checking

often comes from either media organizations like journalists or newspapers (Berlinski et al. 2023), or elections officials (Gaudette et al. 2025; Lockhart et al. 2024; Suttman-Lea and Merivaki 2023). These fact-checking attempts have had varied impact on different outcome measures of voters' trust in elections.

We chose to replicate Berlinski et al. (2023) because it is a prominent study showing that fact-checking from media organizations is unlikely to significantly reduce the impact that misinformation has on voters' trust in elections. One possible explanation is that Americans are increasingly less likely to trust media organizations, who have gained a reputation of writing articles that prioritize engagement over communicating actual information (Trexler 2026).

In contrast, both recent and past research has found that voters' trust in elections and likelihood to turn out at the polls increase when elections officials provide vital information about elections (Gaudette et al. 2025; Lockhart et al. 2024; Suttman-Lea and Merivaki 2023). Because these officials are the ones who organize elections in the first place, voters are likely to messaging from elections officials as from a "genuinely trusted and authoritative source" (Malhotra et al. 2012, 331). But if certain voters are inherently less confident in election integrity or believe that officials are directly responsible for alleged voter fraud, they may be less trustful of official messaging (Suttman-Lea et al. 2025). In addition, the literature has mostly left out another key group of actors interested in rebuilding trust in elections: think tanks and nonpartisan organizations. Policymakers already rely extensively on think tanks to provide the expertise needed for defending their choices of policies - in fact, think tanks are staffed by experts in different fields for the purpose of providing much needed expertise to legislators (Lerner 2018; Bertelli and Wenger 2009). Some nonpartisan organizations are also focused on assisting with election administration efforts across party lines (Adler et al. 2026; Lal and Thompson 2024). On the other hand, think tanks have also had a reputation for producing what Rich (2009, 216) describes as "commentary" - content that ideologically aligns with the beliefs of those who seek their expertise - as opposed to content focusing on the quality of information. The implication is that voters are just as likely to distrust information from organizations they may recognize as think tanks, even if it is designed to convey accurate information about election administration and fraud.

The motivation for our study thus stems from the fact that Americans have reason to both trust and distrust news organizations, elections officials, and think tanks/nonpartisan organizations when they provide fact-checking resources relating to election fraud and meddling - in short, the issue of source credibility suggests that voters may have reasons to trust or distrust experts who provide fact-checking against misinformation (Lupia 2013). Another view could be that voters selectively choose to believe information that subscribes to their own preferences and views, while disbelieving information that goes against their priors (Taber and Lodge 2006). Our study seeks to identify some of the factors shaping when voters choose to believe or disbelieve election misinformation.

Design

Our study is an extension of Berlinski et al. (2023); an illustration of the design can be found in the appendix as Figure 1. We propose to embed both the replication and the novel study within the

same survey, as running the same survey twice would introduce the risk of demand effects among respondents (Mummolo and Peterson 2019). As a result, we have submitted only one survey instrument for both the replication and novel study.

At the start of the survey, respondents will answer several questions typical of all surveys, measuring their general interest and knowledge in politics, their trust in mass and social media on reporting the news, their beliefs in conspiracies, and who they voted for in the most recent presidential election (2024).¹ Respondents will also answer a question asking whether they voted in the 2026 midterm election; this directly corresponds to one of the outcome measures. After a pre-treatment attention check, we use a completely randomized design to assign respondents who pass the attention check into six possible treatment arms. Respondents assigned to the control condition are shown four food-related posts on X; respondents assigned to the “low dose” condition are shown a random subset of four out of eight posts from X where a political figure claimed that election fraud was occurring; respondents assigned to the “high dose” condition are shown all eight of the posts from X where a political figure claimed election fraud was occurring; respondents assigned to the “low dose with news fact-checking” condition are shown the random subset of four posts claiming election fraud, as well as four posts from journalists and media organizations, like the New York Times, linking to articles that fact-check claims of election fraud; respondents assigned to the “low dose with news fact-checking” condition are shown the random subset of four posts claiming election fraud, as well as four posts from elections officials that provide fact-checking of claims regarding election fraud; and respondents assigned to the “low dose with news fact-checking” condition are shown the random subset of four posts claiming election fraud, as well as four posts from think-tanks and nonpartisan organizations linking to articles that fact-check claims of election fraud.

For our treatment condition involving fact-checking from elections officials, our goal is to obtain posts from state elections officials across multiple states in the United States on X. For our treatment condition involving fact-checking from think tanks and non-partisan organizations, our goal is to obtain posts from think tanks and nonpartisan organizations that have produced research on elections without respect to party on X. As with the posts for the other treatment conditions in the replication, we would obtain the exact posts closer to the general elections in November 2026, and all of our social media posts will be obtained solely from the platform X (formerly Twitter).

Our outcome measures will be identical to those of the original survey - respondents will answer seven questions on their confidence in different aspects of elections being properly administered. We will then combine the responses into a single composite outcome variable using a structural equation model and the `psych` and `lavaan` packages in R. Our targeted estimands and estimation process for each novel treatment condition will be similar to those of the replication study.

¹These questions were used in the original study prior to treatment, and will serve as our covariate battery.

Hypotheses and Expected Results

This study plans to test six new hypotheses (predicted effects are bolded), though additional hypotheses may be added prior to pre-registration:

- *H1a: Exposure to four posts claiming voter or election fraud and four posts from elections officials fact-checking claims of voter or election fraud will reduce confidence in elections and support for democracy relative to a placebo. **Consistent with the findings of Berlinski et al. (2023), we expect that the impact of misinformation would still be negative, but reduced significantly by fact-checking from election officials.***
- *H1b: Exposure to four posts claiming voter or election fraud and four posts from think tanks and nonpartisan organizations fact-checking claims of voter or election fraud will reduce confidence in elections and support for democracy relative to a placebo. **Similar to hypothesis H1a, we expect that the impact of misinformation would still be negative, but moderately reduced by fact-checking from think tanks and nonpartisan organizations.***
- *H2a: Exposure to four posts claiming voter or election fraud and four posts from elections officials fact-checking claims of voter or election fraud will reduce confidence in elections and support for democracy less than exposure to four posts claiming voter or election fraud without fact-checks. **Our expectation of the effects and reasoning is identical to that of Hypotheses H1a and H1b.***
- *H2b: Exposure to four posts claiming voter or election fraud and four posts from think tanks and nonpartisan organizations fact-checking claims of voter or election fraud will reduce confidence in elections and support for democracy less than exposure to four posts claiming voter or election fraud without fact-checks. **Our expectation of the effects and reasoning is identical to that of Hypotheses H1a and H1b.***
- *H3a: Exposure to four posts claiming voter or election fraud and four posts from elections officials fact-checking claims of voter or election fraud will reduce confidence in elections and support for democracy less than exposure to four posts claiming voter or election fraud with fact-checks from media organizations. **We predict that fact-checking from elections officials would be more effective at combating the effects of misinformation compared to fact-checking from media organizations for reasons described in Section , and expect this effect to be positive.***
- *H3b: Exposure to four posts claiming voter or election fraud and four posts from think tanks fact-checking claims of voter or election fraud will reduce confidence in elections and support for democracy differently than exposure to four posts claiming voter or election fraud without fact-checks. **Our hypothesis is agnostic to the direction of effects because we believe that voters have equal reason to be persuaded (or unpersuaded) by fact-checking from think tanks and nonpartisan organizations. We would expect, however, that the effect is far from zero regardless of direction.***

We will obtain IRB approval from the University of California, San Diego prior to conducting this study. We also commit to posting a preprint of the findings following the analysis of the novel sur-

vey experiment, along with replication data. All materials, including both proposals and the survey instrument will be stored in a [public GitHub repository](#) for the project, unless instructed otherwise.

Modifications from Original Proposal

As described in our replication proposal, the authors' third treatment effect - the low misinformation + fact-checking treatment - is underpowered. Originally, a power analysis based on the four treatment conditions in the survey experiment suggested that a sample size of about 8,000 individuals, assigned to the four treatment conditions under complete randomization, would mean that all four of the main effects would be sufficiently powered - this was discussed in our original replication proposal. However, this analysis did not factor in the two new treatment conditions for our novel study.

We conducted a new power analysis by simulating data and covariates based on the model specified in the original paper, and including the two new treatment conditions. We chose arbitrary effects for our election official and think-tank fact-checking treatments based off of the hypotheses described above; because we expect that election official messaging will be more effective at providing fact-checking against misinformation compared to the other fact-checking treatments, the effect size is the smallest for that treatment. We also included simulations of estimating the average treatment effects using simple difference-in-means (the specification in the original paper) and covariate adjustment according to Lin (2013).

Figure 2 displays our power estimation when we have a sample of 9,000 respondents for our combined study. First, the left graph indicates that our predicted effects for the media fact-checking and election official fact-checking treatment arms - the smallest effects in our study - would be substantially underpowered when we assign the same number of respondents to each treatment group, regardless of whether we include covariate adjustment (as described in the replication proposal). When we vary the treatment assignment process by assigning a large number of respondents to the control, media fact-checking and election official fact-checking conditions, however, all of the estimates appear to be sufficiently powered, including the election official and media fact-checking treatments.

Another way to consider our issue would be the following: the original study had 4,283 respondents assigned nearly equally to the four treatment conditions, which would mean that each treatment group had approximately 1,070 respondents on average. Assigning 8,000 or 9,000 respondents equally to six treatment conditions means that each treatment group would have approximately 1,333 and 1,500 respondents, respectively, which would not substantially increase the power of the fact-checking effects. However, if we were to hypothetically include a large treatment group, and then vary the size of the treatment conditions based on the number of remaining respondents, we could theoretically ensure that every effect is sufficiently powered based on our hypothesized estimates.

Based on our new power analysis, we would ask for a **sample size closer to 9,000 individuals** instead of our original request for a sample 8,000 respondents. If this proposal is accepted, albeit only with a sample of 8,000 respondents, we would be willing to conduct a similar analysis to determine the most optimal treatment assignment strategy that maximizes the power for all of our treatment arms.

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Appendix

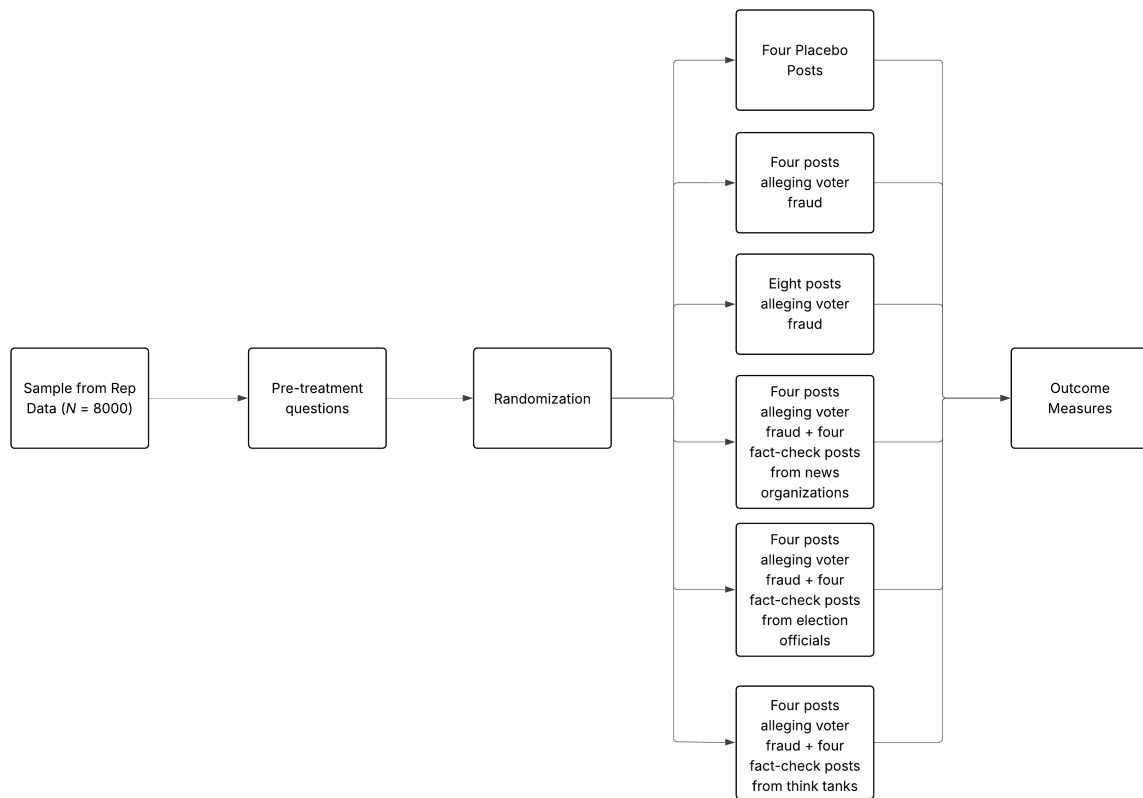


Figure 1: Proposed Experimental Design for Replication and Novel Study.

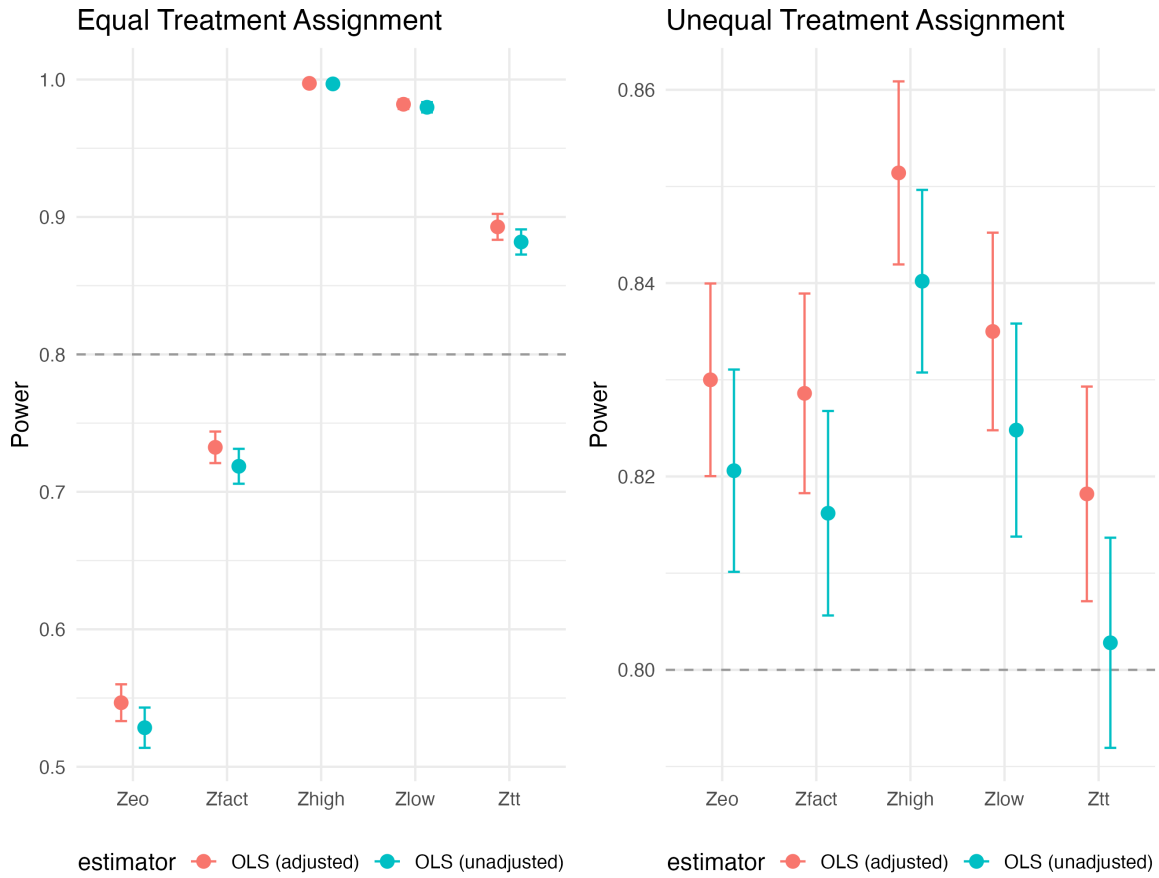


Figure 2: Power estimates by treatment arms and treatment assignment for sample size $N = 9,000$. Equal treatment assignment denotes $N = 1,500$ for each treatment group. The sample was split into the following treatment groups for unequal assignment: 4,050 respondents in the control group, 425 respondents in the low misinformation treatment group, 342 respondents in the high misinformation treatment group, 1,276 respondents in the media fact-checking treatment group, 2,215 respondents in the election official fact-checking treatment group, and 692 respondents in the think-tank fact-checking treatment group.